Customer Role Play

Assessment Development Centre

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Instructions for Assessors:

- **In this role play discussion, the assessor will play the role of the Sandeep Sahrma Procurement & Technical Head, Aether Constructions Pvt Ltd and the participant to play the role Sunil Jain Vice President – Key Accounts & Business Development, Chemistik Industries.**

- Each of the participants would be provided with background information. As part of the simulation, participant is required to conduct a one-on-one meeting with Procurement & Technical Head, Aether Constructions Pvt Ltd and manage the relationship.

The duration of this tool per participant is as follows:

Participant Preparation Time	30 minutes
Discussion Time + Notes Calibration	20 minutes (15 + 10)

Competencies to be assessed with this tool:

Competency & Definition	Key Elements (What to Look For)
1. Result Orientation- reflects the discipline to translate strategic priorities into structured execution, ensuring consistent, high-quality outcomes while upholding governance standards and institutional commitments.	✓ **Goal Focused Execution-** Translates broad organisational priorities into clearly defined objectives, milestones, and accountabilities, ensuring teams understand expectations and timelines. ✓ **Performance Discipline-** Maintains structured review mechanisms, monitors progress through data and discussion, and intervenes proactively when deviations emerge. ✓ **Delivery Reliability-** Honours commitments made to stakeholders and governance forums, ensuring quality standards are upheld, and avoidable delays or lapses are addressed promptly.
2. Commercial Acumen - reflects sound financial and business judgment in strengthening long-term value, balancing growth with prudence, and exercising disciplined choices that protect sustainability within a public sector financial context.	✓ **Value Orientation-** Evaluates initiatives and commitments in terms of their contribution to long-term financial strength, portfolio quality, and sustainable value rather than short-term volume or optics. ✓ **Resource Allocation Judgement-** Prioritises initiatives and commitments based on disciplined deployment of financial and human resources, recognising trade-offs and opportunity costs. ✓ **Risk Return Judgement**- Balances potential benefits against exposure and downside implications, demonstrating proportionality in endorsing growth or commitments.
3. Customer Orientation- embodies the ability to understand customer realities, structure viable and compliant solutions, and negotiate responsibly to balance responsiveness with financial prudence and institutional integrity.	✓ **Customer Insight** - Seeks to understand the customer's financial, operational, and sectoral context before framing responses, ensuring proposals are grounded in realistic conditions. ✓ **Solution Orientation** - Advances structured and compliant solutions that address customer needs without compromising institutional standards or financial safeguards. ✓ **Commercial Negotiation-** Negotiates with confidence and discipline, balancing responsiveness with margin protection, risk proportionality, and long-term sustainability.
4. Executive Communication & Presence - reflects the ability to communicate ideas, risks, and recommendations in a clear and structured manner, while maintaining composure and credibility in formal forums and representing the organisation responsibly in high-stakes interactions.	✓ **Clarity of Communication**- Presents issues, risks, and recommendations in a logically structured and concise manner, enabling informed discussion and decision-making. ✓ **Professional Representation** - Represents institutional positions accurately and responsibly in formal forums, avoiding overcommitment, misinterpretation, or personalisation of matters. ✓ **Executive Presence** - Maintains composure, confidence, and credibility when presenting viewpoints or responding to challenges in high-stakes settings.

Chemistik: Recovering a High-Value B2B Client Relationship

Customer Role Play

Company & Context Background

Chemistik Industries is India's leading manufacturer of adhesives, sealants, and construction chemicals. The company has been aggressively expanding its premium construction chemicals portfolio through technology-led joint ventures, including the Chemistik–Ceramix JV for high-performance tile adhesives and grouts.

Client Profile – Aether Constructions Pvt Ltd

Aether Constructions is a reputed, 18-year-old real estate developer headquartered in Chennai with strong presence across South India (Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh) and selective projects in Maharashtra.

- **Scale**: Annual turnover ~₹2,800 crore. Currently executing 24 active projects with a total developable area of 18.5 million sq.ft.
- **Focus**: Premium and luxury residential townships (70%), high-end commercial spaces (20%), and select institutional/infrastructure projects (10%).
- **Annual Construction Chemicals Spend**: ₹85–95 crore. Tile fixing systems, grouts, waterproofing compounds, and adhesives account for nearly 40% of this spend.
- **Procurement Style**: Centralized procurement with strong technical evaluation. They maintain a panel of 4–5 approved vendors but prefer long-term strategic partners who can offer technical support, consistent quality, and competitive commercial terms.
- **Key Pain Points**: Rising input costs, tight project margins (currently 14–16%), delay in project completion penalties, and increasing demand for faster execution and sustainability-compliant products.

Detailed History of the Relationship with Chemistik

Aether started with Chemistik's standard adhesives and sealants in 2019. By 2022 relationship was transactional but grew steadily due to reliable quality and timely delivery. In 2022, Aether shifted a significant portion of their premium tile fixing requirements to the Roff-Ceramix range. They were impressed with the superior bonding strength, faster setting time, and aesthetic finish of Ceramix epoxy and polymer-modified grouts. By 2024, Chemistik supplied ₹11.2 crore (highest ever). Chemistik enjoyed ~65% share in Aether's premium tile adhesives & grouts wallet. Aether used Chemistik products successfully in 7 flagship luxury projects, receiving positive feedback from architects and end-customers on durability and finish.

From the early months of 2025, the relationship started weakening due to three successive price increases (total ~19% over 18 months) driven by sharp rise in imported raw materials (re-dispersible polymers and epoxy resins). Delivery reliability dropped during the post-monsoon construction surge, there were multiple instances of 2–3 week delays. Technical support at sites became inconsistent; site engineers complained of slow response from Chemistik's technical team compared to competitors. As a result, Chemistik's share dropped from 65% to ~28% in premium category. Annualized offtake is now only ₹4.8 crore.

Current Situation in Hand

Aether is in the final stage of vendor selection for two major upcoming projects:

- **Project 1**: “Aether Lakeview” – Luxury waterfront residential township in Chennai (Phase 2) – Potential chemical value: ₹14 crore over 24 months.
- **Project 2**: “Aether Horizon” – Premium high-rise commercial complex in Bengaluru – Potential chemical value: ₹14 crore over 18 months. Total Opportunity: ₹28 crore over the next 2 years.

Aether has shortlisted Apex BuildChem (an aggressive South Indian competitor) as the lead supplier. Apex is offering:

- 14–18% lower prices than Chemistik’s current quoted rates.
- Dedicated site technical engineers for each project.
- 75-day credit terms.
- Faster delivery commitment (within 5 days of order).

The Senior Vice President – Procurement & Technical Services has agreed to give Chemistik one final 1:1 meeting before they sign the contract with Apex BuildChem. This meeting is scheduled in Aether’s Chennai headquarters.

Aether’s Current Stance & Expectations

- They still acknowledge that Ceramix products offer technically superior performance (better adhesion in wet areas, lower efflorescence, longer life).
- However, they are no longer willing to pay a “premium” without commensurate value in service, pricing stability, and support.
- Specific demands likely to be raised:
    - Price rollback or protection for the next 18–24 months.
    - Volume-based rebate structure.
    - Dedicated on-site technical team (at least 2 engineers per major project).
    - Improved credit terms (from current 45 to 60–75 days).
    - Guarantee delivery timelines with penalty clauses.
    - Flexibility to develop “value-optimized” variants without compromising core performance.

Also, there is ongoing internal pressure on Aether. Their management has mandated a minimum 8–10% reduction in construction material costs for new projects due to softening real estate demand and higher borrowing costs.

Role Holder Profiles

- **Candidate Role: Vice President – Key Accounts & Business Development, Chemistik Industries**
  You own the P&L responsibility for strategic corporate accounts in the construction chemicals vertical. Your mandate is to protect and grow high-value client relationships while maintaining healthy contribution margins. Losing Aether completely would mean a significant revenue hit and damage to Chemistik’s reputation in the premium developer segment.

- **Assessor Role: Procurement & Technical Head, Aether Constructions Pvt Ltd**
  You are an experienced procurement professional with strong technical knowledge. You are responsible for optimizing chemical construction costs while ensuring quality and timely execution for Aether’s projects. You are highly frustrated with recent price hikes and service lapses from Chemistik and under pressure from management to reduce project costs by 8–10%. You respects Ceramix technology but believes “good enough” performance at lower cost is now acceptable.

Role Play Setup

You; Sunil Jain (Chemistik VP – Key Accounts) are meeting the Sandeep Sharma Procurement & Technical Head of Aether Constructions in their corporate office in Chennai. This is a make-or-break 1:1 discussion.

Aether is about to award the next 18-month contract to your competitor. Your goal is to retain minimum 60–70% wallet share of the ₹28 crore opportunity with healthy margins, rebuild trust, and lay the foundation for a stronger long-term partnership.

Assessor Scoring Guide

1. Customer Orientation

Key Probing Questions:

1. **Opening / Empathy Probe:** "Frankly, we are very disappointed with how things have gone in the last 18 months. Three price hikes, delivery delays, and poor site support have made it difficult for us to continue with Chemistik at the same level. How do you see the situation from your side?"
2. **Understanding Client Needs Probe:** "We are under huge pressure to cut construction material costs by 8–10% because of softening demand and high interest costs. Why should we continue giving significant business to Chemistik when Apex BuildChem is offering 14–18% lower prices with much better service?"
3. **Long-term Partnership Probe:** "Even though Ceramix products are technically superior, we can manage with 'good enough' performance if it saves us money. What makes you think Chemistik truly understands and cares about Aether's current business challenges?"

2. Commercial Acumen

Key Probing Questions:

1. **Pricing Probe:** "Your current prices are still 12–15% higher than Apex even after some discount. We need price protection or a rollback for at least the next 24 months. What can you offer?"
2. **Value vs Price Probe:** "We acknowledge Ceramix quality is better, but the price difference does not justify the extra cost anymore, especially with project margins under pressure. How do you justify the premium?"
3. **Creative Deal Probe:** "If we commit to ₹12–15 crore annual volume across both projects, what commercial package (discounts, rebates, credit, support) can Chemistik realistically put on the table?"

3. Result Orientation

Key Probing Questions:

1. **Ownership Probe:** "The business has dropped from ₹11.2 crore to ₹4.8 crore annualized. What went wrong on Chemistik's side and how do you plan to fix it?"
2. **Commitment Probe:** "What exact volume and share are you targeting from the two new projects (Lakeview and Horizon)? Be specific."
3. **Execution & Accountability Probe:** "We have heard many promises before. How will you ensure that whatever you commit today on delivery, technical support, and pricing, will actually be delivered?"

4. Executive Communication & Presence

Key Probing Questions:

1. **Pressure / Challenge Probe:** "To be honest, we are 80% inclined toward Apex BuildChem because of their responsiveness and pricing. Convince me why we should still choose Chemistik."
2. **Conflict Probe:** "Your technical team has been slow to respond to site issues. Our site engineers say Apex is far more proactive. How do you respond to that?"
3. **Closing / Decision Probe:** "If we were to move forward, what are the 2–3 non-negotiable commitments you need from us, and what firm commitments are you ready to make today?"